



Seen, Not Sure

A School Messaging App’s Read Receipt Against What Guardians Actually Recall

Torun Ezeigwe · Sten Okwuosa · Joost Nwosu — School of Continuous Improvement

The problem

A primary-school messaging app logs a “seen by” timestamp the moment a guardian opens a notice. Schools treat the tick as proof the message landed. Does opening a notice mean anything in it was understood?

What we set out to test

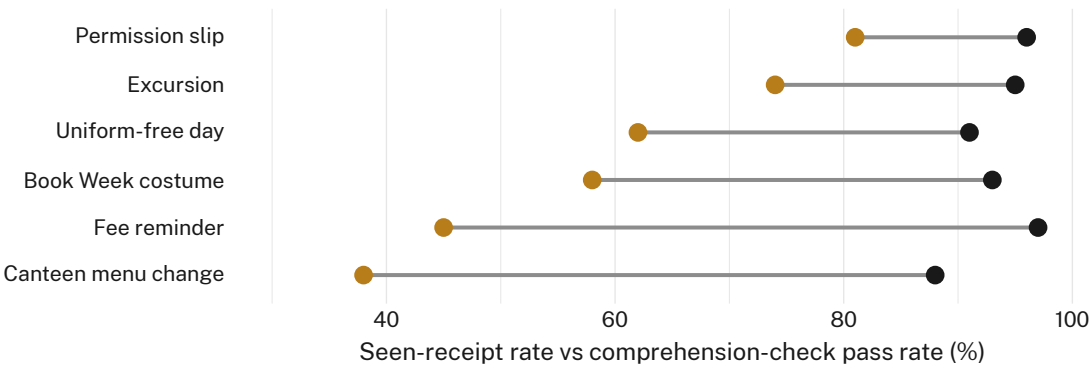
- Cross-reference each notice’s seen-receipt log against guardians’ recall of its content
- Compare the seen rate and the comprehension rate across notice types
- Test whether a deadline or a fee attached to a notice widens the gap

Study design

- n = 618 guardian-notice pairs · 9 primary schools · 1 messaging app
- Comprehension checked by a single follow-up question at pickup, within 48 hours of the seen timestamp
- Notice type, deadline presence, and days-to-follow-up held as covariates

Findings

The seen-receipt rate holds high and stable across notice types (88-97%); the comprehension rate does not track it. Guardians recorded as having seen a notice answer no more accurately, on average, than those the app logged as never opening it.



Seen-receipt rate holds within a nine-point band across notice types (88-97%, March-June 2026); comprehension trails by 15 points on permission slips and by 50 on canteen menu changes.

What it means

A guardian-level correlation between seen-status and comprehension-check accuracy sits at $r = 0.14$ (n = 618) — indistinguishable in strength from guessing which notices were logged as unopened. The receipt tracks whether a screen was tapped, not whether anything on it survived the tap.

Next: extend the comprehension check to a one-week recall window, to see whether the gap widens or simply relocates.

Selected references

1. Chou, Y.-L., Lin, Y.-H., Lin, T.-Y., You, H. Y., & Chang, Y.-J. (2022). Why Did You/I Read but Not Reply? IM Users’ Unresponded-to Read-receipt Practices and Explanations of Them. CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems. doi:10.1145/3491102.3517496
2. Markert, P., Lassak, L., Golla, M., & Dürmuth, M. (2024). Understanding Users’ Interaction with Login Notifications. Proceedings of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems. doi:10.1145/3613904.3642823
3. Kraft, M. A., & Rogers, T. (2015). The underutilized potential of teacher-to-parent communication: Evidence from a field experiment. Economics of Education Review, 47, 49–63. doi:10.1016/j.econedurev.2015.04.001
4. Pietrzykowski, T., & Smilowska, K. (2021). The reality of informed consent: empirical studies on patient comprehension — systematic review. Trials, 22, 57. doi:10.1186/s13063-020-04969-w
5. Achterberg, L., & Hanke, M. (2026). Marked for the Camera: A Staff Survey on Deliberate Whiteboard Use Under a Meeting-Room Engagement Photo-Audit. Slop University. doi:10.5555/slop.yjud2l

Comprehension checks administered verbally at pickup; no phone screens inspected. Guardian responses de-identified at collection.

Contact: torun.ezeigwe@slop.university · Office of Research Outputs

🐦 @slop.university · #slopU



“Every notice was marked seen. Almost none of it stuck.”

94.2% of notices logged as read across nine primary schools; comprehension didn’t follow.